

Aurelia Grand Hotel Group

Front Desk Complaint Handling Playbook

Guest complaint intake, triage, communication, handoff, and closure standards

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Purpose and usage

This controlled document defines operational standards for hotel teams. It is intended to support consistent decisions, clear accountability, accurate record keeping, and high-quality service recovery across Aurelia properties. Teams must apply local legal requirements when those requirements are stricter than this standard.

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1. Complaint Handling Principles

Front desk and guest experience teams are responsible for making the guest feel heard while preserving accurate records and operational accountability. A complaint should never be treated as an interruption; it is an opportunity to correct the stay and protect trust.

- Listen without defensiveness and acknowledge the specific concern.
- Collect enough information to identify the stay, room, timing, and impact.
- Avoid promising a remedy before reviewing records unless an immediate goodwill gesture is authorized.
- Assign an owner before the guest is passed to another department.
- Record actions in neutral, factual language.

Principle	Good practice	Avoid
Acknowledge	"I'm sorry the room was not ready to the standard you expected."	"That should not have happened, but..."
Clarify	"Can you tell me when you first noticed the AC issue?"	Interrogating the guest or implying disbelief.
Own	"I will coordinate with engineering and update you by 6:00."	"You need to call maintenance."
Close	"Here is what we have done and what happens next."	Leaving the guest unsure who is handling the case.

2. Channel-Specific Intake Standards

Complaints may arrive by phone, in person, email, chat, web form, or third-party review. The channel changes the intake method, not the requirement to identify the issue and create a complete case note.

Channel	Required intake	Special handling
Phone call	Caller name, booking identifier, room, issue, timing, requested follow-up.	Summarize back to guest before ending call.
In person	Immediate acknowledgement, room number, visible impact, preferred	Offer seat or private area for

	contact method.	sensitive issues.
Email	Attach email body and files to case; confirm receipt if resolution needs time.	Do not reply with generic apology if records are needed.
Chat/web form	Capture transcript and any screenshots or photos.	Clarify stay dates if missing.
Review platform	Record public review link and booking match if available.	Public response should not reveal personal stay details.

Photos and attachments

Guest-provided photos should be saved with the case when relevant. Staff should not ask for photos in a way that delays immediate correction for an in-house guest. If the guest is still on property, offer staff inspection or room move promptly.

3. Triage and Escalation Rules

Trigger	Immediate action	Escalation owner
Safety, security, injury, harassment, discrimination, privacy, or pest allegation.	Keep guest safe, notify duty manager, follow incident protocol.	Duty manager / Security / General manager.
Guest still in room with comfort issue.	Offer correction, room move, or temporary mitigation.	Front office supervisor.
Maintenance defect affecting sleep, hygiene, or room use.	Create engineering ticket and flag guest impact.	Duty manager if unresolved same shift.
Serious cleanliness issue.	Request housekeeping supervisor inspection and immediate reclean or move.	Executive housekeeper or delegate.
VIP or corporate account complaint.	Notify responsible manager and account owner if relevant.	Duty manager / Account owner.

Response targets

- In-house urgent issue: acknowledge within 10 minutes.
- In-house non-urgent issue: acknowledge within 30 minutes.
- Post-stay email complaint: acknowledge same business day.
- VIP material complaint: manager acknowledgement same day.
- Cases requiring investigation: provide expected update time.

4. Case Notes and Evidence Capture

Case notes should be factual, chronological, and respectful. A later reviewer should be able to understand what was reported, what was checked, what was decided, and which departments were involved.

1. Record guest identity and stay details.
2. Summarize the complaint using the guest's words where practical.
3. Record timing: when issue occurred, when reported, and when staff responded.
4. Attach relevant email, call summary, photos, staff notes, and department records.
5. Record department actions, remedy discussion, and approvals.

6. Close with final response sent, remedy posted, and follow-up task owner.

Neutral language standard

Do not label guests as difficult, dishonest, angry, or unreasonable in case notes. Describe observable behavior and facts, such as “guest raised voice during call” or “guest requested full refund before evidence review.”

5. Communication Templates and Approved Phrases

Templates should be adapted to the specific case. The best responses name the issue, acknowledge impact, state action taken, and avoid overexplaining internal policy.

Use when	Approved phrasing
Initial acknowledgement	Thank you for bringing this to our attention. I am sorry this affected your stay, and I will review the records with the relevant team.
Verified hotel responsibility	Our review confirmed that this did not meet our standard, and we have taken corrective action with the responsible department.
Partially verified	Some records support the concern you raised, and while not every detail can be confirmed, we recognize the impact on your stay.
Unsupported after review	We reviewed the available records and were unable to confirm the issue as described. We still appreciate you sharing the feedback.
Follow-up timing	I will update you by [time/date], even if the review is still in progress.

Phrases to avoid

- “That is impossible.”
- “You should have told us earlier.”
- “Our policy does not allow that” without explanation or ownership.
- “There is nothing we can do.”
- Any language that blames another department or staff member.

6. Shift Handoff and Closure

Open complaints must be handed over clearly at shift change. The receiving team should not need to repeat basic questions to the guest unless facts are missing.

Handoff element	Required detail
Guest and room	Name, room, booking ID, contact method.
Issue summary	What happened, when reported, current guest status.
Actions taken	Departments contacted, tickets created, temporary remedies.
Pending decisions	Evidence needed, manager approval, financial posting.
Promised update	Time and person responsible.

Closure quality

A case may close only when the guest has received a response, approved remedies are posted, department tasks are assigned, and the case note explains the decision. Level 3 and 4 cases require manager review before closure.

7. Reference Checklist for Front Office Leaders

Checklist item	Question
Identify	Do we have guest name, room, stay dates, and contact method?
Understand	Do we know what happened, when, and how it affected the guest?
Act	Has the immediate operational correction been assigned?
Review	Have relevant records been checked before financial remedy?
Approve	Is the remedy within authority and documented?
Close	Has the guest received the final response and has the department task been created?

Leaders should use this checklist during shift handoff and for any complaint likely to require compensation or manager review.

8. Call Flow for Angry or Distressed Guests

- Let the guest speak without interruption long enough to understand the core issue.
- Acknowledge the emotion and the specific service failure.
- Confirm the booking details and whether the guest is currently in-house.
- State the next action and the update time.
- Create or update the case note before moving to the next task.
- If the guest becomes abusive or threatening, follow safety and escalation procedure while remaining calm.

Moment	Recommended language
Opening	I am sorry this has affected your stay. I am going to take ownership of the next steps.
Clarifying	To make sure I handle this correctly, can I confirm the room number and when this started?
Setting expectation	I need to check the room and maintenance records. I will update you by 6:00 today.
Closing	I have recorded the case and assigned the next action. You will not need to repeat this from the beginning.

9. Public Review and Reputation Responses

Public review responses should be brief, respectful, and privacy-conscious. Do not confirm room numbers, stay dates, compensation, or personal details in public. Invite the guest to continue privately when the booking cannot be matched.

- Thank the reviewer for the feedback.
- Acknowledge the issue category without revealing private details.
- State that the property is reviewing or has addressed the matter where accurate.
- Provide a private contact route.
- Avoid defensive explanations, policy arguments, or public disputes.